

Chapter 16-1

Liang Shi drove back to the hospital.

As soon as she returned, Qiu Zimin called.

"Ah Shi." Qiu Zimin sounded somewhat serious, but calling her by her pet name still seemed affectionate, "Did you meet Zhou Yi'an?"

Liang Shi leaned against the wall, her back feeling the cold.

The lights in the hospital room were off, and the interior was completely dim.

She lightly pressed her lips together, her voice also very quiet, with a slight obscurity, "I met her."

"How did it feel?" Qiu Zimin asked, then continued without waiting for an answer, "You should also divorce that person from the Xu family. She's just a sickly person, and not even the Xu family's biological child. For her sake, our family has already invested seventy to eighty million—that's not a small amount. But your parents love you, and since you liked her before, we didn't say anything and just let you have your way."

"But looking at it now, the Xu family is just a bottomless pit. Xu Guangyao¹ just isn't business material—their family company will go bankrupt sooner or later. It's better to withdraw early. What Zhou Yi'an can offer is much more than you imagine. If we can't get that piece of land in the south of the city, you..."

"What will happen?" Liang Shi interrupted her, asking coldly.

Qiu Zimin suddenly stopped.

She had never heard Liang Shi speak in such a tone before.

Usually, although this daughter had a bad temper, she was always obedient in front of her and never said a harsh word.

She frowned, "What kind of attitude is this?"

Liang Shi breathed out lightly, "What attitude do you think I should have?"

"Liang Shi, can't you just speak directly? Why do you have to be so sarcastic with your mother?" Qiu Zimin was also angry and said sternly, "You asked me to arrange this meeting, didn't you? So I arranged it. Even if you're not satisfied with Zhou Yi'an now, you don't need to take this attitude with me, do you? I've been doing my best to help you. I was the first to agree when you wanted to marry Xu Qingzhu. You're my daughter—how could I harm you?"

Liang Shi pinched her temples, "Yes, you wouldn't harm me."

It sounded calm but carried a hint of mockery.

Qiu Zimin answered confidently, "Of course not. You're flesh of my flesh—I'm the person who loves you most in this world. How could I harm you?"

"Is that so?" Liang Shi smiled sarcastically.

In the darkness, all emotions were infinitely magnified.

The complex emotions from the private room earlier all extended to this moment, transforming into anger.

"Don't you believe me?" Qiu Zimin laughed coldly, "Liang Shi, what's wrong with you? Why don't you even believe your mother's words? I've raised you for so many years—what did I do wrong to be treated like this by you?"

"Then do you know that Zhou Yi'an is an Alpha?" Liang Shi said coldly.

There were several seconds of silence on the other end of the phone.

Even the breathing stopped.

"I don't know," Qiu Zimin said.

Her tone was somewhat awkward.

"Then do you know that when two Alphas are together, one of them will get sick?" Liang Shi asked.

Qiu Zimin's end was silent again.

After a while, she said, "Of course I know, but what does this have to do with you?"

"What do you mean by introducing Zhou Yi'an to me?" Liang Shi said, "You know she likes me, so you want to use me to exchange for that piece of land in the south of the city? I really couldn't have imagined that I'm worth so much."

Qiu Zimin became anxious, "Ah Shi, your mother doesn't mean that. Alphas can be together too. Yi'an doesn't mind that you've had a marriage before, and you can become her lover. The most important thing for two people together is love. Your mother knows a doctor—there's now technology to change an Alpha into a Beta or Omega, and it doesn't harm the body."

"So you did know all along," Liang Shi said, "So your suggestion is for me to divorce Xu Qingzhu, undergo a differentiation surgery², become a Beta or Omega, and marry Zhou Yi'an. That way the Liang family can get that piece of land in the south of the city, right?"

Qiu Zimin's end fell silent.

A few seconds later, she hung up the phone.

Sometimes silence can represent many things.

Liang Shi emptied her mind in this endless silence, letting her thoughts drift freely.

After a while, she received text messages from Qiu Zimin:

【Ah Shi, if it weren't absolutely necessary, your mother wouldn't do this either. You know that among the four children, your mother loves you the most. No matter what you do, your mother always supports you the most. The Liang family's financial problems now are more difficult than you can imagine. After all, you've lived in this house for over twenty years—you're part of this family. Xinzhou and Xinhe have been working hard at the company, and Wanwan³ is still young. Now only you can help the Liang family get through this crisis. Just consider it your mother begging you. That piece of land in the south of the city determines the Liang family's life and death, and now you're the key. If you decide not to care, the Liang family might go bankrupt within two months, and then our whole family... never mind, pretend your mother didn't say anything.】

【Your mother was confused. Rest early, and next time you come home, your mother will apologize to you in person.】

Liang Shi read these two text messages expressionlessly and directly turned off her phone.

Qiu Zimin's words were actually very clear.

If she didn't marry Zhou Yi'an and get that piece of land in the south of the city, the whole Liang family would have to drink the northwest wind⁴.

At the end, she even used a strategic retreat⁵.

It seemed like she was backing down, but she was actually forcing Liang Shi to submit.

This kind of tactic didn't seem like it was being used for the first time.

The original body had probably complied before.

Because Liang Shi had a memory in her mind that was transmitted just as she was making the phone call.

In a dark room, the original body was wearing gauze clothing and tied to a bed. The gauze was almost transparent, and the person standing by the bed wore black leather clothing and held a whip. In the darkness, you couldn't see that person's face clearly, but the sound of the whip hitting flesh was very harsh.

The original body endured it without making a sound.

Liang Shi's hearing was tormented by that memory.

Fortunately, there weren't many such fragments.

In that memory, there was also Qiu Zimin's voice praising the original body: "Ah Shi did really well."

At the same time, Liang Shi was thinking about the scene just now—Zhou Yi'an had said "long time no see" to her.

So previously, the original body and Zhou Yi'an had known each other.

But Liang Shi had no idea how much interaction they'd had.

And Liang Shi suspected that Qiu Zimin should know that the original body wasn't her biological child.

That's why she would use such despicable methods to torment the original body.

Footnotes:

¹ **Xu Guangyao (許光耀)**: Xu Qingzhu's father, who apparently isn't good at business.

² **Differentiation surgery (分化手術)**: In ABO dynamics, a fictional medical procedure that can change someone's secondary gender (Alpha/Beta/Omega classification).

³ **Wanwan (晚晚)**: A pet name, likely referring to another sibling in the Liang family who is younger.

⁴ **Drink the northwest wind (喝西北風)**: A Chinese idiom meaning to have nothing to eat, to go hungry, or to be in dire financial straits.

⁵ **Strategic retreat (以退為進)**: A Chinese idiom describing a tactic where someone appears to back down or give up in order to actually achieve their goal by making the other party feel guilty or responsible.

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Liang Shi had to sigh once again—what kind of mess had the system thrown at her?

Moreover, Qiu Zimin had just said on the phone that Xu Qingzhu wasn't the Xu family's biological child either.

Did Xu Qingzhu know this?

Since she arrived, she hadn't met Xu Qingzhu's parents, but from the information she'd searched, Xu Qingzhu's parents treated her extremely well.

Just from the fact that Xu Qingzhu was willing to marry the original body to save the family enterprise, her parents' treatment of her shouldn't be bad.

Liang Shi had mild OCD¹. She went to the hospital room's private bathroom and carefully washed her hands, including the wrist area that Zhou Yi'an had touched.

Her wrist now gave off a faint orange fragrance, and only then did she feel satisfied.

She turned off the bathroom light and, in the dim moonlight, took off her jacket and hung it by the door. She let down her hair that had been casually tied up while driving, didn't even turn on the lights, and went straight to lie on the bed.

She was somewhat tired.

Liang Shi had finally managed to change her life from hard mode to normal mode, and now it had directly jumped to hell difficulty.

Anyone would have a mental breakdown.

She lay there, but her mind was still clear.

Her phone kept spinning in her hand, occasionally tapping the bedsheets.

After a moment, she turned over and suddenly had a flash of inspiration.

If the way to gain luck points was to pursue Xu Qingzhu, then she just needed to satisfy all of Xu Qingzhu's requirements.

What Xu Qingzhu wanted most right now was divorce, wasn't it?

Then she could just agree to divorce.

If she couldn't say it out loud, she could send a message.

Liang Shi felt she had fallen into a thinking trap before. Now that she understood, she immediately picked up her phone and sent a message to Xu Qingzhu: 【I agree to your request. Let's get divorced.】

She clicked send.

A few seconds later, a small red dot appeared in front of the message.

It showed "Send Failed."

Liang Shi: "...?"

No signal?

She tried sending another message: 【If divorce is what you want, then let's divorce. From now on, let's continue to get along as friends.】

The second half of that sentence was basically empty words.

Xu Qingzhu probably never wanted to see her again in this lifetime.

But it still showed "Send Failed."

Liang Shi carefully checked her phone—all the apps that required internet connection were working.

Only messages to Xu Qingzhu couldn't be sent.

She tried again, sending: 【Are you asleep?】

Immediately, a phone vibration sounded in the hospital room, and a light source lit up on the bedside table, reflecting on the pristine white ceiling.

Liang Shi was startled. Before she could sit up to check, a clear, cold voice came from beside her: "Are you looking for me?"

It was Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi reached to turn on the light, but Xu Qingzhu said, "Don't turn it on. Let's just chat."

Liang Shi: "..."

She pressed her lips together, sitting restlessly on the bed.

Then Xu Qingzhu patted the spot next to her, "Want to lie down?"

She asked without any hint of sensuality.

But to Liang Shi's ears, it sounded very much like "Want to sleep together?"

Her ears itched, and her heart itched too.

Liang Shi hesitated for a moment, but still lay down.

She had no choice—she was too tired.

"What did you want to chat about?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu didn't answer, only asked, "Was this your first time meeting Zhou Yi'an?"

The room suddenly fell into an eerie silence.

"Liang Shi," Xu Qingzhu said coolly, "Perhaps you need a shoulder?"

The drowsy Liang Shi suddenly became alert. She looked over and could only see Xu Qingzhu's profile in the dim light.

For a moment, she couldn't figure out what Xu Qingzhu was trying to do.

Her attitude toward her had undergone a complete transformation within half a day.

Liang Shi had always believed that when things were abnormal, there must be something fishy.

But she did quite want to absorb some warmth.

As she hesitated about how to answer, Xu Qingzhu suddenly turned over and rolled directly to her side.

"You..." Liang Shi had just started to speak when Xu Qingzhu's finger landed on her lips, saying in a low voice, "Don't speak."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her finger also carried that faint orange fragrance—it smelled very nice.

It made one's mind wander.

Xu Qingzhu rested her head on her shoulder, her voice muffled and deep, "Then lend me your shoulder."

Footnotes:

¹ **OCD (潔癖)**: In Chinese, this term can refer to both obsessive-compulsive disorder and general cleanliness/hygiene perfectionism. In this context, it refers to Liang Shi's need for cleanliness and order.